

COVER STORY TERRORISM

organisations owning up to the attacks has become the most defining and macabre signature of the terror outfit. Last week's serial blasts in Delhi offers a chilling testimony to their pan-India presence and—more frightening—their ability to strike anywhere and at any time.

The Delhi blasts also exposed the inability of the security agencies to tackle the spreading terror threat. Even Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, while asserting that "Pakistan-based terrorist outfits are constantly trying to set up new modules within the country", admitted that the latest blasts are "a matter of utmost concern" and that "recent terror strikes in various cities show vast gaps in intelligence". He also went on to admit that "the role of Pakistan cannot be minimised, but the involvement of local elements in the recent blasts adds a new dimension to the terrorist threat."

Intelligence agencies believe that Pakistan still uses Dawood's network to orchestrate terrorism but the IM is a convenient fig leaf to hide behind. The IM is, on the face of it, totally home grown, led, formed and nurtured by Indian Muslims—mainly members of the outlawed Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI) harbouring a deep-rooted, if distorted, sense of persecution and desire for revenge. The literature they sent to the media spoke of the Babri Masjid destruction and the Gujarat riots as the prime reason for their acts of depravity. They did so in the name of Allah, "the merciful".

Such a perverse belief would be understandable if the leadership and propagandists were illiterate and uneducated. That is not the case with the IM. Its top leaders arrested earlier this year include Safdar Nagori, 37, and Mufti Abu Bashir, 28, who operated under the leadership and guidance of Abdus Subhan Qureshi alias Tauqeer, 32, the shadowy figure, who is the mastermind of the Bangalore, Ahmedabad and Delhi blasts, referred to as "BAD" in interrogations of suspects picked up in Ahmedabad. He is being described by intelligence agencies as India's Osama bin Laden. Tauqeer is a software engineer, who first came to prominence in 2001 when he quit his IT job in Mumbai to join SIMI to take over as the editor of their English mouthpiece. He was present at a SIMI meeting in Indore in 2001, which was raided but he managed to slip away—an act he had duplicated earlier the same year when he was present at the SIMI headquarters in Zakir Nagar in south Delhi when it was raided and key members arrested.

Tauqeer is a Mumbai resident (his family still lives in Mira Road). In a press conference, his mother Zubeda Qureshi said her son should be

THE EMERGING LEADERSHIP

Based on interrogations and follow-up investigations, this is the leadership structure of Indian Mujahideen:

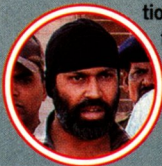
ABDUS SUBHAN QURESHI ALIAS

TAUQEUR, 36: Now the most wanted man in India. A software engineer from Mumbai, he worked for a leading computer firm before he joined SIMI and took to jihadi activity. He also worked as the editor of two radical Islamic magazines



called *Movement* and *Shaheen Times*. An expert in bomb-making and author of the virulent e-mails that precede every bomb blast by the Indian Mujahideen, Tauqeer is believed to have masterminded most of the blasts that have occurred in the past two years. He is an expert hacker.

SAFДАР NAGORI, 38: Architect of past terror strikes and the transformation from SIMI to Indian Mujahideen. He broke from



SIMI moderates three years ago to take it to the terror route. A former diploma engineer from Ujjain, Nagori has been the strongest votary of the home-grown Jihadi movement.

MUFTI ABU BASHIR,

28: An Islamic preacher from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh, who also taught in a madrasa in Hyderabad, he is one of the main ideologues of the Indian Mujahideen.

Till his arrest, his role was to motivate youths for the jihadi cause. He supervised the planning of terror attacks along with Tauqeer and Qayamuddin Kapadia. Currently under arrest, he is totally unrepentant about killing innocents in the blasts.

QAYAMUDDIN KAPADIA,

28: A small-time trader of Vadodara, he heads the Gujarat unit. Absconding from the day Nagori was arrested, he was the main coordinator for the

Ahmedabad blasts and planting bombs in Surat along with Sajid Mansuri. His

role involved overseeing the purchase of bicycles and selecting the bomb sites. He is also believed to have played a key role in the Delhi blasts as a second-in-command to Tauqeer. Kapadia started the first-ever mosque



of the Ahle Hadis Tanzeem (one of the two Wahhabi tanzeems) in Vadodara a few years ago.

SAJID MANSURI,

35: One of the oldest members of SIMI, he had managed to give the police a slip when the Surat police caught 123 SIMI activists in 2001. He was not only the coordinator for the Ahmedabad blasts and



for planting bombs in Surat but took an active part in the Jaipur bomb blasts also. The bomb that went off opposite Hawa Mahal was placed by him. A graduate in psychology, Sajid worked as a marketing executive for some time before becoming active in SIMI. Currently under arrest.

USMAN AGARBATTIWALA,

25: A PG diploma holder from Vadodara in human rights, Agarbattiwala played the most important role in the Ahmedabad bomb blasts. Pipe bombs resembling the

